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AfD, Vox mingle with ex-US Border Patrol chief, white nationalist leader at ‘remigration summit’

Gregory Bovino and Jared Taylor flew in to support activists once deemed too toxic even by European far-right parties.

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The United States’ former Border Patrol chief Gregory Bovino was a VIP guest at the tightly controlled event that also included elected officials from Spain's Vox and Germany's Alternative for Germany (AfD). | Marion Solletty/POLITICO

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BY MARION SOLLETTY

PORTO, Portugal — European far-right activists who advocate the mass deportation of immigrants and their descendants are getting a boost from the Trump administration's embrace of their key catchword: remigration.

Some 500 activists and influencers gathered south of Porto on Saturday to discuss the concept, once a fringe term only whispered in far-right circles. The United States' former Border Patrol chief Gregory Bovino and American white nationalist Jared Taylor were VIP guests at the tightly controlled event, which also included elected officials from Spain's Vox and Germany's Alternative for Germany (AfD) parties.

Other leading European far-right parties, most prominently France's National Rally, have avoided the term or rejected the policy as too extreme because it targets migrants based on their ethnicity or religion. But U.S. President Donald Trump's use of the word and the American State Department's pledge to create an office for remigration put wind in the sails of longtime advocates of the policy in Europe.

"When the word is acknowledged by the president of a major power … one can no longer say that it is marginal," Jean-Yves Le Gallou, a former MEP for the French far right under Jean-Marie Le Pen, said at Saturday's "Remigration Summit 2026".

The gathering took place in the coastal city of Figueira da Foz, 135 kilometers south of Porto, and welcomed activists from all over Europe, the U.S. and Canada.

"I am very happy to come over and lend some expertise to the Europeans" to tackle "illegal aliens destroying European culture," said Bovino at an impromptu press conference at the gate.

In an interview with a far-right website ahead of the summit, Bovino — who didn't wear his controversial coat — referenced Nazi Germany's lead general Erwin Rommel as an inspirational figure and offered his help to end what he described as a "creeping horror," echoing racist terms used by far-right extremists to describe migrants.

"If there is inspiration gained from the U.S. Border Patrol model and method, then fantastic," added the former Border Patrol chief, who was dismissed from his position after agents under his command killed a 37-year-old nurse in Minneapolis.

Sellner's moment

The Porto summit was co-organized by Austrian far-right activist Martin Sellner, who first came into the spotlight in 2024 after holding a secretive meeting in Potsdam, Germany, where he discussed the remigration concept with AfD politicians. News of the Potsdam gathering triggered large-scale protests in Germany at the time, with many pointing to parallels with early plans for the mass deportation of Jews during World War II.



Martin Sellner speaks during a protest in Vienna on April 13, 2019. | Michael Gruber/Getty Images

Two years later, a confident Sellner made himself available to journalists for interviews at the remigration summit, dwelling on concepts that he says are now going mainstream.

"We have a very neurotic relationship to our own ethnicity, our own ethno-cultural identity and I think we need to overcome that," Sellner told reporters at the summit, calling on Europeans to overcome their "guilt complex" and "self-loathing" stemming from "post-war consensus."

At least three AfD politicians attended the event, including Kay Gottschalk, a member of the Bundestag and one of the party's cofounders. Gottschalk said he was there "to listen" as "a visitor." Lena Kotré, an AfD member and representative in the Brandenburg state legislature, spoke on stage. Sven Tritschler, a member of the North Rhine-Westphalia parliament, also was in attendance.

Vox MPs Rocío de Meer and Carlos Quero featured on the summit's speakers list. Activist Sammy Woodhouse, a supporter of U.K. right-wing party Restore Britain, was also among the speakers.

Tensions emerged when reporters who had been accredited to cover the event were not allowed in and instead were confined to the parking lot. At one point, a drone buzzed over the press pack making repeated, aggressive moves toward a female journalist there.

Queuing for selfies

By contrast, multiple right-wing influencers equipped with high-tech gear were welcomed inside, with the summit's social media channels boasting "enormous" interest partly thanks to Bovino's presence.

Among the speakers were Dries Van Langenhove, a former Belgian MP twice convicted for hate speech, and far-right Dutch activist Eva Vlaardingerbroek, a promoter of the so-called great replacement conspiracy theory, according to which mainstream and political elites are conspiring to bring in large numbers of non-white migrants to replace white populations. The theory was referenced in the event's promotional material.



Far-right Dutch activist Eva Vlaardingerbroek was among the speakers at the summit. | Marion Solletty/POLITICO

Attendees also queued to take selfies with Taylor, the U.S. white nationalist who is a high-profile promoter of racialist ideology. "The United States influences Europe more than the other way around," Taylor said outside the venue. "But among dissidents and identitarians, at least, there is a great deal of interest in Europe."

Organizers and speakers whom POLITICO talked to at the venue all denied the accusations of racism that hang over the movement.

"I don't consider myself a hateful person," said Canadian activist Daniel Tyrie, who was on one of the panels. "I don't go around spitting on people of color because they're in my country."

"I just don't think they belong here."

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